because the alternative is loss of dominion and enslavement. Beyond this arena of competitive imperialism as necessary to survival lie other causes, such as the predominantly male desire to acquire goods and land, food and women. In the 'Warring States' period of China in the fifth and fourth centuries BCE we see that controlling territory became crucial to the consolidation of political domination, while in the 1400s the 'Flower Wars' of the Aztecs aimed to seize people required as sacrificial victims for the gods.[15] Over much of ancient history, territorial expansion also ensured enormous economic benefit. The acquisitions of the Assyrian king Ashurnasirpal II (*c*. ninth century BC) are an example. Even among his smaller campaigns, the booty included 40 chariots with men and horses, 460 horses, 120 pounds of silver, 120 pounds of gold, 6000 pounds of lead, 18,000 pounds of iron, 1000 vessels of copper, 2000 heads of cattle, 5000 sheep, 15,000 slaves, and the defeated ruler's sister.[16]

How much of this *weltanschauung* formed part of the mental horizons of Ashoka cannot be specifically known, but conquerors and kings from the West were very much part of political happenings in South Asia at the time his own grandfather captured power. So the possibility of this emperor having been influenced by the world beyond South Asia is very far from being remote. Plutarch, in his biographical history of Alexander, says Chandragupta, when a mere lad, saw Alexander in person. When he began to rule from Pataliputra, embassies from the Western powers came to his court; later, in Bindusara's years as sovereign, they were there again. A charming story told about him and Antiochus I of Syria highlights this: the Indian monarch asked for sweet wine, dried figs, and a sophist, to which Antiochus's reply was that while figs and wine would be sent, it was forbidden by law to sell a sophist![17]

The expedition to Kalinga was preceded by massive arrangements, from ascertaining the strength of the enemy's forces to understanding the terrain through which the army would move to working out the logistics of the